

The SHRM-CP Behavioral Competency Map

Name the competency. Pick the answer. The reasoning SHRM grades on — with 6 worked scenarios.

By Dave, founder of [CipherExam](#)

Why this sheet exists

Senior HR pros routinely fail SHRM-CP. Not because they lack knowledge. Because they've spent twenty years making **pragmatic** HR calls, and the exam grades against **idealized** competency frames.

Three of the four options on most SHRM-CP situational questions are *defensible* HR moves. The "right" answer is the one that most visibly enacts a specific SHRM behavioral competency.

This sheet gives you:

1. **The Lens** — the single question SHRM grades against
2. **A clean map of the nine behavioral competencies** and what each one looks like in the wild
3. **6 worked scenarios** showing the lens in action
4. **The 3 traps** SHRM-CP situational questions are built around

If you internalize the lens, the situational questions stop feeling like guesswork.

The Lens, in one sentence

What aligns with SHRM behavioral competencies?

That's it.

Before you read any of the four options on an SHRM-CP situational question, ask: **which behavioral competency is the scenario testing?** Once you can name it, the right answer is the one that most directly demonstrates *that* competency.

Most wrong answers are good HR — they just demonstrate the wrong competency, or no competency at all. That's how memorization-prep candidates miss: they pick the "pragmatic" answer when the exam is grading whether you can enact the named competency.

The 9 behavioral competencies — a working map

SHRM organizes the behavioral competencies into three clusters. Here's the working map. The "what it looks like" column is what to ground your eye on during the exam.

Cluster 1 — Leadership

Competency	What it tests	What it looks like in a scenario
Leadership & Navigation	Steering the organization through change and uncertainty	Enabling change, removing obstacles, building organizational support for a direction
Ethical Practice	Acting with integrity and accountability	Confronting unethical behavior even when it's politically costly; protecting the principle, not the person

Cluster 2 — Interpersonal

Competency	What it tests	What it looks like in a scenario
Relationship Management	Building and maintaining trust across stakeholders	Mediating, repairing relationships, building coalitions
Communication	Exchanging information effectively across audiences and channels	Translating, framing, listening, escalating with context
Global & Cultural Effectiveness	Working effectively across cultures and identities	Adapting communication and practice for cultural context without losing core values

Cluster 3 — Business

Competency	What it tests	What it looks like in a scenario
Business Acumen	Understanding business operations and aligning HR with strategy	Speaking the language of revenue, margin, headcount cost, business risk
Consultation	Guiding leaders to make better people decisions	Advising the manager, building their capability, not solving it for them
Critical Evaluation	Interpreting data and information to make sound decisions	Using turnover data, engagement scores, exit interview themes — not gut feel
HR Expertise (BoCK)	Technical HR knowledge across functional areas	Knowing the laws, knowing the best practices, applying the right policy — this is the "knowledge" piece

A clean memorization shortcut: **LR-EC, RC-CM-GC, BA-CN-CE-HR**. Or just learn the cluster pattern (Leadership / People / Business) plus the nine names.

The 3 SHRM-CP trap types

After the lens, the second-biggest unlock is recognizing how SHRM constructs wrong answers:

Trap 1 — Pragmatic but uncompetency-shaped

The option is something a senior HR pro would actually do in real life — defer to a respected manager, give a top performer a pass, escalate to legal early. **SHRM is not grading pragmatism. It's grading whether you can name the competency and act it.** Pragmatic-but-shapeless answers are wrong even when they're what you'd do at work.

Trap 2 — Right competency, wrong move

The option enacts a competency — but not the one the scenario is testing. Example: the scenario tests Consultation (advising a manager) and the option enacts Critical Evaluation (running an engagement survey). Both are HR moves; only one is what's being tested.

Trap 3 — Replace-the-manager

The option has HR taking the action that should be the manager's action. SHRM rarely grades HR doing the manager's work. It grades HR *enabling* the manager to do their own work better. If the option starts

"HR escalates to..." or "HR replaces the manager with..." check whether the better answer is "HR coaches the manager to..."

Scenario 1 — A top performer skipping process

A high-performing manager is consistently late submitting performance reviews. Her director defends her — "she's a top producer, leave her alone." What does HR do?

Options: - **A.** *Defer to the director and let it go* - **B.** *Escalate to the CHRO* - **C.** *Coach the director on why timely performance management matters to the org* - **D.** *Document the pattern and address the manager directly*

Naming the competency: This is **Consultation**. The scenario gives you a leader (the director) who's making a decision HR can influence by advising them, rather than going around them or capitulating.

Walking through: - A defers — that's Trap 1 (pragmatic but uncompetency-shaped) - B escalates over the director — that's Trap 3 (replace-the-manager-style escalation; the director hasn't been engaged yet) - D goes around the director straight to the manager — that's also Trap 3, and damages Relationship Management - C *enables the director* to make a better people decision. That's Consultation enacted directly.

Right answer: C.

The lens at work: you're not asked "what should be done about the late reviews." You're asked "what would HR, doing Consultation well, do here?"

Scenario 2 — A culturally insensitive joke at an all-hands

During an all-hands meeting, a senior executive makes a joke that lands poorly with employees from a specific cultural background. Several Slack DMs reach you immediately. What's your first action?

Options: - **A.** *Send a company-wide email apologizing on the executive's behalf* - **B.** *Privately address the executive, explain why the joke landed where it did, and discuss next steps including a possible public statement* - **C.** *Issue a written warning to the executive per the code of conduct* - **D.** *Wait to see if formal complaints come in before taking action*

Naming the competency: This is **Global & Cultural Effectiveness**, supported by **Ethical Practice** and **Relationship Management**. The scenario is testing whether you can engage someone privately, with

cultural framing, while still acting on the principle.

Walking through: - A apologizes over the executive — Trap 3 (replace-the-manager pattern) - C jumps to a formal warning without conversation — disproportionate, weak Relationship Management - D waits — Trap 1 (pragmatic but unprincipled; SHRM grades Ethical Practice, not legal caution) - B privately addresses, frames the cultural impact, and *together* decides on next steps. That's the cluster of Global & Cultural Effectiveness + Ethical Practice + Relationship Management acting at once.

Right answer: B.

The lens at work: SHRM tests *first actions*. The right first action is private, principled, and respects the person while serving the principle.

Scenario 3 — A data-driven turnover concern

Voluntary turnover in the sales organization has risen 28% year over year. The VP of Sales says it's "market dynamics." What does HR do first?

Options: - **A.** Accept the VP's read and continue routine work - **B.** Run exit-interview theme analysis across the last 12 months of sales departures and present findings to the VP - **C.** Propose a retention bonus program to the CHRO - **D.** Survey current sales employees about engagement

Naming the competency: This is **Critical Evaluation**. The scenario is testing whether you can interpret data before recommending action.

Walking through: - A defers without data — Trap 1 - C jumps to a solution before diagnosis — gives a remedy without a hypothesis - D surveys, which is fine but skips the cheaper data already in hand (exit interviews already happened) - B uses existing data, themes the findings, and presents to the decision-owner. That's Critical Evaluation done well.

Right answer: B.

The lens at work: Critical Evaluation graded on the exam isn't "run a survey." It's "use the data you already have, structured, before proposing a fix." Exit interviews are gold and underused.

Scenario 4 — A high-stakes ethical situation

An employee comes to you (HR) with credible evidence that a senior manager is falsifying expense reports. The manager is well-liked, a major revenue producer, and the CEO's golf partner. What does HR do?

Options: - **A.** *Defer the issue to the legal department* - **B.** *Investigate per policy, document findings, and surface them per the escalation matrix — regardless of the manager's standing* - **C.** *Quietly counsel the manager to stop, without formal documentation* - **D.** *Speak with the CEO informally before doing anything*

Naming the competency: This is **Ethical Practice**, anchoring the response. Secondary: **Communication** (the escalation) and **HR Expertise** (the policy).

Walking through: - A punts — pragmatic but Trap 1 - C softens the principle to protect the relationship — that's the *opposite* of Ethical Practice - D plays politics — Trap 1 again - B follows policy, documents, surfaces regardless of who it implicates. That's Ethical Practice acted

Right answer: B.

The lens at work: Ethical Practice questions on the exam are *uniformly* about following the principle when it's politically costly. The "diplomatic" answer is almost always wrong here.

Scenario 5 — Cross-functional restructuring

The CEO has decided to merge two departments. Both have entrenched cultures and the merger will eliminate ~15 roles. The CEO asks HR to "lead the change." What's the first HR move?

Options: - **A.** *Draft the layoff communication and severance package* - **B.** *Hold a town hall to announce the merger and invite questions* - **C.** *Meet with the leadership of both departments to understand the operational dependencies, surface change-readiness factors, and propose a sequenced approach* - **D.** *Run an employee engagement survey to baseline morale before the change*

Naming the competency: This is **Leadership & Navigation**, supported by **Business Acumen** and **Consultation**.

Walking through: - A jumps to execution before strategy — Trap 1 (pragmatic, undirected) - B announces before planning — premature comms tank Leadership & Navigation - D measures without acting — useful background but not the first move - C scopes the operational dependencies (Business Acumen), consults with the leadership (Consultation), and sequences the change (Leadership & Navigation). All three competencies acting at once.

Right answer: C.

The lens at work: Leadership & Navigation graded on the exam looks like "first understand the system you're changing." Acting before scoping is Trap 1's signature.

Scenario 6 — A new policy meeting resistance

You've rolled out a new flexible-work policy. Three months in, several managers are quietly ignoring it and requiring in-office days that the policy makes optional. Employees are confused. What does HR do?

Options: - **A.** Send a reminder email to all managers about the policy - **B.** Discipline the noncompliant managers per HR policy - **C.** Meet with the noncompliant managers to understand why they're deviating, and use those conversations to either reinforce or refine the policy - **D.** Survey employees to measure the policy's success

Naming the competency: This is primarily **Consultation** — engaging managers to make better people decisions, with the option to apply **Critical Evaluation** (if the policy is actually wrong, find out).

Walking through: - A is empty performance — Trap 1 - B punishes without understanding — Trap 3 (replace-the-manager) and may be enforcing a flawed policy - D measures without engaging — useful eventually, not the first move - C understands first, then decides whether to reinforce or refine. That's Consultation and Critical Evaluation in service of Leadership & Navigation.

Right answer: C.

The lens at work: when policy meets resistance, the SHRM-graded move is to *understand the resistance* before enforcing or capitulating.

Your next move

You now have:

1. **The Lens.** Name the SHRM behavioral competency before reading the options.
2. **A working map of the nine competencies** and what they look like in scenarios.
3. **The 3 trap types.** Pragmatic-but-shapeless, right-competency-wrong-move, replace-the-manager.
4. **6 worked scenarios** spanning Leadership, People, and Business clusters.

Reading this sheet is step one. **Building the reflex is step two**, and that takes reps on situational questions — preferably ones that tell you which competency they were testing after you answer.

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